



Norwegian Fjords

The most complex coastline in the world, a maze of long, deep marine channels, many overlooked by high cliffs

A fjord is an elongated ocean inlet, originally created by the action of glaciers over thousands or millions of years. While fjords are found in many countries, those of Norway are particularly magnificent, numerous (around 1,000), and in many cases exceptionally long.

A fjord-dominated landscape runs as a strip all around Norway's coast. This has a unique appearance, with a tangle of islands and peninsulas interspersed between the fjords themselves. Except in the area where they meet the sea, fjords are much deeper than typical coastal plain estuaries. Sognefjord, for example,

reaches a maximum depth of 4,300 ft (1,300 m). Many Norwegian fjords have vertical cliffs on one or both sides, rising to a height of up to 3,300 ft (1,000 m).

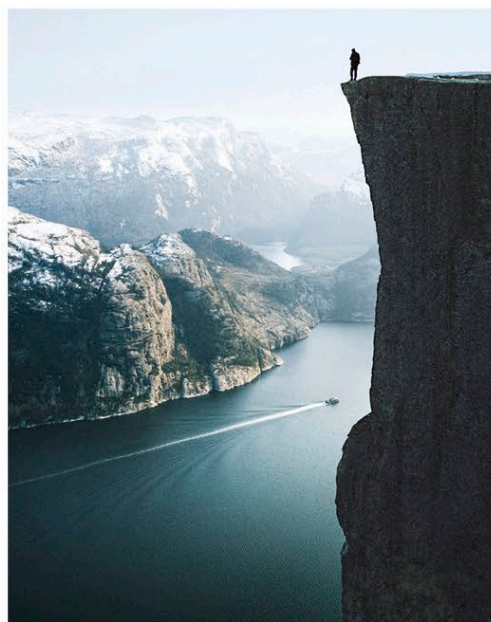
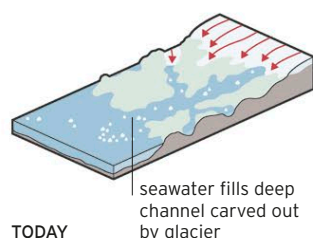
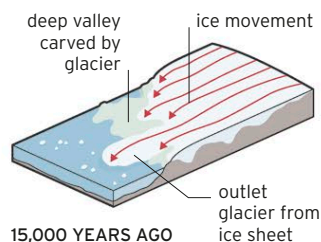
Fjord life

Life in Norway's fjordland centers on picturesque fishing villages, which are connected by an extensive system of ferries. Wildlife includes marine mammals such as seals and porpoises, sea eagles, and millions of other seabirds, including colorful puffins. The harbor porpoise—one of the smallest marine mammals—is commonly seen here and feeds on small schooling fish.

Fjords **lengthen Norway's coast** by a factor of ten, to over **19,000 miles (30,000 km)**

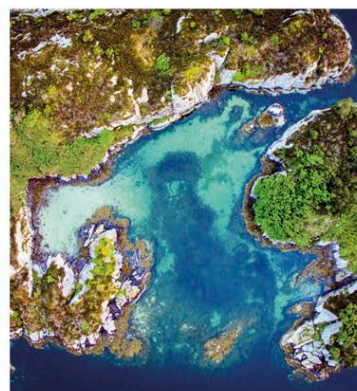
HOW FJORDS FORM

During the last glacial period, huge glaciers extending down from a vast ice sheet scoured deep U-shaped valleys. As the glaciers melted and the sea level rose, seawater flooded into these valleys, forming fjords.



△ SHEER DROP

Soaring 2,000 ft (600 m) above Lysefjord, Pulpit Rock is one of Norway's most visited landmarks. It is popular for activities such as cliff jumping.



△ TURQUOISE PASSAGE

The waters of Hjeltefjord meander between islands in Hordaland County, southwestern Norway. Hjeltefjord is around 25 miles (40 km) long.

▷ STUNNING ENTRANCE

Traditional fishing huts can be seen near the mouth of Kierkfjord in the Lofoten Islands. A short distance from the mainland, the Lofotens are blessed with exquisite scenery.

